

Session 8: Magi and Herod

Key Takeaways

- Herod I was widely known for his extravagance, paranoia, and cruelty. Matthew immediately links this villainous figure to the power structures of Jerusalem in Jesus' day.
- The Magi represent the fulfillment of the prophetic promise that the nations would recognize the coming of God's rescue for the world.
- Matthew adopts imagery from Isaiah 60 to present Jesus as the new Jerusalem.

Matthew 2:1-12

A ¹ Now, when **Jesus** had **been** born in **Bethle'em** of **Joudaia** ,
in the days of **Herodes the king** ,
look, **magi** from **the eastern regions** arrived in **Hierosoluma** , ² saying,

B "Where is the one **born king** of the **Joudeans** ,
because we saw **his star in the east** ,
and **we have come to bow down to him.**"

A' ³ And when **King Herodes** heard,
he was troubled, and all of **Hierosoluma** with him,

⁴ and having gathered all the chief priests and scribes of the people,
he inquired from them **where** the **messiah** is to be **born** .

⁵ And they said to him
"In **Bethle'em** of **Joudaia** ,
because that's how it was written through the prophets,
⁶ 'And you, **Bethle'em** of the land of **Jouda** ,
you are by no means least among the **rulers** of **Jouda** ,
because from you will come **a ruler** ,

who will shepherd my people, Israel.”

7 Then **Herodes**, having privately called **the magi**,
he learned precisely from them the time of **the shining star**,

A 8 and having sent them to **Bethle’em**, he said,
“As you go make a careful examination about **the child**,
and when you find him, **report to me**,
so that **I too may come and bow down to him.**”

9 And having listened to **the king** they went,
and look, **the star** which they saw **in the east**,
it went ahead of them until going on it stood over the place where **the child** was,

10 and seeing **the star**, they rejoiced with very great joy,
B a 11 and coming into **the house**,
b they saw **the child** with Maria his mother,
c and falling down
d **they bowed down to him**,
c' and opening up their treasures,
d' they brought to him gifts of gold, frankincense, and myrrh,

A' 12 and having been warned in a dream **not to return** to **Herodes**,
they departed by another road unto their own country.

Matthew 2:1-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024)

Herod the Great and Ruthless

The Herods were a royal family from Idumea, far southeast of Israel, a tribal kingdom that was forcibly converted to Judaism around 127 B.C.E. by John Hyrcanus II (a Hasmonean ruler over Israel).

Herod I was appointed by the Romans as leader of Galilee first and then later, in 37 B.C.E., over most of Israel as tetrarch (ruler of a 1/4 kingdom). He converted Jerusalem to his rule and installed friends and allies in all of the important positions, including the temple. He supported the Roman emperors so consistently that he kept being rewarded with more and more land onto his kingdom. By 20 B.C.E., he ruled over the entire region formerly ruled by the Jewish Hasmoneans.

Herod engaged in many building projects whose ruins still remain to this day (Caesarea by the sea, Jerusalem, Masada).

Herod's final years (he died in 4 B.C.E.) were fraught with court intrigue, assassination attempts, and mental anguish. He had no clear heir and was unable to name his successor (his 10 wives bore him 15 children). He murdered one of his wives out of fear of a coup, and he had two of his sons, Alexander and Aristobulus, executed for a plot to assassinate their father and seize his throne. He ordered that a number of populist leaders who opposed him be executed on the day he died, to ensure that there would be mourning in the land (see Josephus, *Antiquities of the Jews*, sec. 173-175).

He divided up his kingdom into thirds shortly before his death of an intestinal disease. He appointed Herod Archelaus over Israel, Antipas over Galilee and Perea, and Philip over the rest.

Needless to say, the king's paranoia highlighted by Matthew is entirely in character for what we know of Herod from other historical sources.

"Herod matters for two reasons. First, in his attempt to slaughter the Messiah he is like the Pharaoh of Jewish tradition, who sought to kill the first redeemer, Moses. Secondly, Herod, although he could boast no royal genealogy, was a king, and our evangelist is interested in contrasting his rule and kingdom with the rule and kingdom of Jesus the Davidic Messiah."

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2000). [*A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel According to Saint Matthew, vol. 1*](#). T&T Clark. 227.

Jerusalem in Trouble

Jerusalem is here introduced for the first time in Matthew's account, and the portrait is not flattering. The city is associated with Herod and his ruthless plans to consolidate power and eliminate rivals. In the story moving forward, Jerusalem becomes identified with Israel's corrupt leadership who will violently oppose Jesus. In fact, [Matthew 2:3](#) is part of a network of hyperlinks throughout the story that portray Jerusalem as a hostile opponent to Jesus.

Matthew 2:3 Instructor's Translation

And when King Herodes heard,
he was **troubled, and all of Ierosoluma** with him,

Matthew 16:21 Instructor's Translation

From then on, Iesous began to point out that it was necessary for him to go to **Ierosoluma**,
and to suffer many things by the elders and chief-priests and scribes,
and to be killed,

Matthew 21:10-11 Instructor's Translation

¹⁰ And after he entered into **Ierosoluma**,
all of the city was shaken, saying,

"Who is this one?!"

¹¹ But the crowds said,

"This one is the prophet Iesous,
who is from Nazeret of Galilaias!"

Matthew 23:37 Instructor's Translation

Ierousalem! Ierousalem! The one who killed the prophets,
and who stoned-to-death those sent to her;
how many times I have desired to gather your children together,
in the way a mother-hen gathers her chicks under her wings;
but y'all did not desire it.

Micah Fused With Samuel

The words of the prophet Micah quoted by the chief priests and scribes come from Micah 5:2, but Matthew supplies an additional line to the end of the quotation that comes verbatim from an important story in 2 Samuel 5:1-3.

Matthew 2:6 (quoting Micah 5:2)

And you, Bethlehem, land of Judah,
are by no means least among the leaders of Judah;
for out of you shall come forth a ruler,
who will shepherd my people Israel.

Micah 5:2, 4

² "But as for you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, though
little among the clans of Judah, from you one will
go forth for me, to be a ruler in Israel,

his goings forth are from long ago, from the days
of eternity."

⁴ And he will arise and shepherd his flock in the
strength of the Lord,

2 Samuel 5:1-3

¹ Then all the tribes of Israel came to David at
Hebron and said, "Behold, we are your bone and
your flesh. ² Previously, when Saul was king over
us, you were the one who led Israel out and in.
And the Lord said to you,

'You will shepherd my people Israel,
and you will be a ruler over Israel.'"

³ So all the elders of Israel came to the king at
Hebron, and King David made a covenant with
them before the Lord at Hebron; then they
anointed David king over Israel.

Micah and Matthew. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

The additional line "who/you will shepherd my people" comes verbatim from the Old Greek translation of 2 Samuel 5:2. This is a line spoken by the elders of the non-Judahite tribes who acknowledge David as their divinely appointed king. They appeal to God's own choice, quoting God's words that David "will shepherd my people Israel." They also acknowledge that the previous king, Saul, has now been displaced by David.

This is surely part of the ironic effect that the additional line creates within Matthew's context, where there is also an illegitimate king with a dubious claim to kingship, namely Herod, to whom these words are being spoken!

It is also important to notice that within the local context of [Micah 5:2-4](#) the same idea appears in different words, namely that this “ruler” from Bethlehem will “arise and shepherd his flock.” In other words, these two passages were already linked together with matching language and imagery, and the fact that Matthew has blended their words together shows that he not only recognized the connection, but he sought to make it explicit and bring out the inner meaning of both texts.

The Messianic Shepherd

In blending the quotes from [Micah 5](#) and [2 Samuel 5](#), Matthew has portrayed Jesus with two of the most iconic messianic images from the Hebrew Scriptures: king and shepherd. Matthew has also, by means of these images, developed one of the major themes of his entire account, namely that Jesus the Son of God is the messianic shepherd king from the house of David.

Matthew will explicitly develop this shepherd theme throughout the story.

Matthew 2:6 Instructor's Translation

And you, Bethle’em of the land of louda,
you are by no means least among the rulers of louda,
because from you will come a **ruler**,
who will shepherd my people, Israel.

Matthew is quoting [Micah 5](#) and [2 Samuel 5](#).

Matthew 9:36 Instructor's Translation

And when he saw **the crowds**, he had compassion on them,
because they were **troubled and scattered**,
like sheep not having a shepherd.

Matthew 10:5-6 Instructor's Translation

⁵ These the twelve Jesus sent,
having instructed them, saying,
“Onto the road of the nations you will not depart,
and into a city of the Samaritans you will not enter,
⁶ but rather **go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel**,

Matthew 15:24 Instructor's Translation

And he responded saying,
“I was not sent, except to **the lost sheep of the house of Israel.**”

Matthew 18:12-14 Instructor's Translation

¹² How does it seem to you?
If there were to a certain man, **one hundred sheep**,
and **one of them wandered off**,
wouldn’t he leave the ninety-nine on the hills,

and going, seek the wandering-one?

¹³ And whenever it happens that he finds it,
amen, I tell you,
he will rejoice over it,
more than over the ninety-nine who did not wander.

¹⁴ Similarly, **it is not the desire before your Father in the skies,
that one of these little-ones would be lost.**

These images of the “troubled,” “scattered,” and “lost” sheep all derive from the language of the Hebrew prophets, specifically Jeremiah 23 and Ezekiel 34. These prophets, both of whom offered a minority report against the leaders of Israel in the years leading up to Jerusalem’s destruction by Babylon, criticized the leaders of Israel in very similar language.

- Jeremiah 23:1-6 criticizes the priest and kings of Jerusalem for scattering the sheep of Israel through neglect and abuse. God’s response is to gather the sheep under the leadership of new shepherd, specifically a “righteous branch for David.”
- Ezekiel 34 is a similar criticism of Jerusalem’s leaders who feed themselves and “who do not strengthen the weak, nor heal the sick, nor bind up the wounded nor bring back the scattered” (Ezek. 34:4).

Matthew wants us to see the entire ministry of Jesus to Israel in the category of these ancient prophetic hopes of a new royal shepherd from the line of David.

The Magi From the East

The famous “wise men” are called “magi” (Grk. *magos* singular / *magoi* plural: *μαγος* / *μαγοι*).

The term originally designated Persian officials of a priestly standing who specialized in the interpretation of dreams, astronomical signs (i.e., astrologers), and other ritual practices associated with the Zoroastrian religion of the East. The term is used in the Old Greek translation of Daniel to describe Nebuchadnezzar’s court sorcerers (see Dan. 2:2, 10).

By the 1st century C.E., magi was a general term for astrologer and ritual expert. Matthew does not specify if “east” means they are Babylonian, Arabian, or Persian.

Because *magos* has a decidedly negative connotation elsewhere in the New Testament (Acts 8:9-11, 13:6-8), it’s possible that Matthew includes this story to provide a contrast with Israel’s current rulers—while Herod and the current establishment in Jerusalem does not recognize Jesus as Israel’s messianic King, even the mysterious magi of the nations can discern the arrival of God’s Messiah, and they eagerly come!

“Whatever the social and religious unsuitability of magi, the fact that they were not Jews fitted more congenially with Matthew’s universalist agenda. To have the 'King of the Jews' recognized and honored first not by his own people but by representatives of the 'many' who were later to come from east and west to take their place in the kingdom of heaven (Matt. 8:11) appropriately set the scene for the ministry of the Israelite Messiah who would both be rejected by his own people (here foreshadowed by the stance of Herod and 'all Jerusalem,' see on v. 3) and send out his disciples to recruit from all nations (28:19).”

The Magi and the Messiah's Star

The magi associate the star they saw with Israel's king ("we saw his star"). This perhaps alludes to a popular ancient belief in a heavenly herald who would arise to signal the arrival of a new king (see Pliny the Elder, *Natural History*, 2:28; Plato, *Timaeus*, 41D-E; Horace, *Epistles*, 2.2.187).

Also, Matthew likely words their speech in a certain way so that it alludes to multiple Hebrew Bible hyperlinks that connect the rising of a star with the arrival of Israel's messiah and with the dawn of Israel's restoration.

Numbers 24:17 LEB

I see him, but not now;
I behold him, but not near;
a star will tread forth from Jacob,
and a scepter will rise from Israel;

The Magi and Isaiah's New Jerusalem

Matthew deliberately adopts language from Isaiah's depiction of the new Jerusalem and applies it to Messiah Jesus.

Isaiah 60:1-14 LXX/Septuagint

¹ **Shine! Shine** (φωτιζω), Jerusalem, for **your light** (το φως) is come,
and the glory of the Lord has **risen** (ανατελλω) upon you.

² Look! Gloom will cover the earth,
and darkness will be upon the nations,
but **the Lord will appear** (φαινω) **over you**,
and his glory will be seen upon you.

³ **Kings will walk in your light and nations in your splendor ...**

⁵ ... because the wealth of the sea and of **the nations and of the peoples will come to you**.
And present with you will be herds of camels,

⁶ and camels of Midian and of Ephah will cover you.
Everyone from Sheba will **come bearing gold** (χρυσιον),
and they will **carry frankincense** (λιβανος)
and **proclaiming the good news of the Lord's rescue** (το σωτηριον κυριου ευαγγελιουνται) ...

¹⁴ **And the sons of those who made you low and provoked you will go to bending low,**
and **you will be called "City of the Lord," "Zion of the Holy One of Israel."**

"The motif of the pilgrimage of the nations to Zion ... has been messianically transformed—the magi come to pay homage to the king of the Jews ... so that the goal of the pilgrimage is not Jerusalem, but Bethlehem. This modification corresponds to the negative role Jerusalem plays in the Gospel of Matthew ... The coming of the gentiles is no longer conceivable as a pilgrimage to Jerusalem, but has been transformed into a coming to the Messiah."

Reflection Question

What does it mean that Matthew presents Jesus as the new Jerusalem?